

Last Gift of Prometheus

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Darwin, Prometheus, and the Evolution of Human Intelligence

Prologue: Prometheus

Prometheus gave humanity fire, and with fire came a strange kind of freedom. Humans no longer had to accept the conditions imposed upon them by nature in quite the same way. They could heat themselves rather than grow fur, preserve food rather than depend entirely on seasonal abundance, and transform raw material into tools rather than wait for their bodies to change. Fire had more to offer than just heat. It was a way of solving the human limitation by outsourcing it.

The myth is easy to read as a story about a gift. When the gods made the creatures of the earth, Epimetheus handed out the gifts: fur, claws, speed, wings. By the time he reached humans, nothing was left, and they stood naked against the cold. So his brother Prometheus stole fire from the gods and carried it down in a hollow fennel stalk. Zeus chained him to a rock, where an eagle ate his liver each day and it grew back each night. The gift was real, and so was the price. And people were never given a better body, only a way to need one less.

That is the idea worth holding onto: externalisation. Again and again, humans encounter a limitation and answer it with something that lives outside the body. A sharpened stone stands in for claws. A woven garment stands in for fur. A written mark stands in for a memory that would otherwise die with its owner. Each time, the limit remains in the flesh, but it stops governing the outcome.

Humans would repeat this act countless times.

But long after Prometheus, humans would create something stranger than fire: a tool that could begin to perform the function that made the species powerful in the first place.

Part I: Darwin's World

In 1859 Charles Darwin published an idea so simple that, reportedly, one colleague wondered how he had failed to think of it himself. Alfred Russel Wallace had in fact arrived at it independently. Organisms exist within environments they did not design. Those environments impose constraints, and populations contain variation. Some variations prove more advantageous under particular conditions than others, and across generations the distribution of those traits can change. No guiding hand and no plan were required.

Evolution did not require organisms to understand their circumstances. It did not reward intention. A species did not become better because it needed to become better. Its environment simply determined which variations persisted. Stripped to its logic, the process is a chain: variation, selection pressure, differential survival and reproduction, and inheritance across generations. Repeat it for long enough and the population itself has changed, without anyone, or anything, having intended it.

Darwin did not know how inheritance worked. That gap was filled in the early twentieth century, when the rediscovered work of Gregor Mendel on heredity was joined to natural selection, and again in 1953 with the structure of DNA. A bold theory became the organizing framework of biology. The geneticist Theodosius Dobzhansky put it this way: "Nothing in biology makes sense except in the light of evolution."

Its reach goes well beyond the textbook. Antibiotic resistance is natural selection happening in real time inside hospitals. Viruses change as they spread through populations, which is why vaccines must be updated. Tumors evolve within a single body, with treatment acting as a selection pressure. Farmers have long exploited the same logic through selective breeding, which Darwin himself used as the opening argument of his book.

The idea has also migrated into technology. Beginning in the 1960s and 1970s, computer scientists wrote genetic algorithms: programs in which candidate solutions vary, are scored against a measure of fitness, and the best are recombined to produce the next generation. Evolutionary

search has been used to design things humans would not have thought to draw, including an oddly bent antenna for a NASA spacecraft. Training modern AI systems is not literally evolution, since most of it relies on gradient-based optimization rather than selection among competing copies, but it shares the same skeleton: a measure of fitness, repeated variation, and refinement across many iterations. Historians of technology have likewise described inventions as lineages that vary, compete, and are selected.

That is why the idea travels so easily. Natural selection is not really a theory about animals. It is a theory about any system in which there is variation, a pressure that sorts it, and some way for what survives to be passed on. Biology is where this logic first operated, and where Darwin first saw it, but it is not the only place it can run.

It is worth being precise about what this process is not. Natural selection does not occur because a species "fails to adapt." It is not a verdict handed down on laggards. Selection is happening all the time, whether a population is thriving or struggling. What can follow from a failure to adapt to changing conditions is decline or extinction, but that is an outcome of the process, not the process itself.

That distinction matters, because the question this essay eventually asks is not whether humans will be punished for something. It is what happens when the conditions that shape a species change faster than the species can.

Part II: The Species That Changed the Rules

Humans did something unusual, and Darwin's own finches show how unusual. When finches reached the Galápagos, they spread across islands with different foods, and over many generations their beaks diverged: thick for cracking seeds, slender for probing flowers, until they were separate species, each shaped to its niche. That is the normal pattern. A population meets a new environment, and the environment slowly rewrites the population.

Humans met nearly every environment on the planet, from desert and rainforest to Arctic ice and high mountain plateaus, and did not split into separate species to do it. Human populations did undergo biological adaptation, sometimes substantially, but culture provided a second and much faster mechanism for adapting to local environments. What changed from place to place was mostly not the body but the knowledge: how to find water, what to hunt, how to build shelter, how to read the weather.

That something else is a second channel of inheritance. In Darwin's chain, what is passed on is carried by genes, and it moves from parent to offspring one generation at a time. Humans added a channel that works through learning. A discovery made by one person can be taught to a child, a neighbor, or eventually a continent, within a single lifetime, and it can be improved by the next person who learns it. Knowledge ratchets upward, because each generation inherits what the last one worked out and starts from there.

That changes the speed of everything. A trait carried in genes needs many generations to spread through a population. An idea can spread in a season. A species that adapts through ideas can answer a changing world far faster than any species that must wait for its genes to catch up, and that advantage is what let a fragile animal spread across the whole planet.

It also changes the nature of the environment. The finch inherits an island. Humans increasingly inherit a world that earlier humans reshaped, with farms, cities, medicine, and tools already in place.

The body stayed remarkably constrained, while its surroundings became more and more the product of human intelligence. That is one of the major ideas of this essay: human intelligence allowed humans to adapt faster than their biology ever could.

Part III: The Outsourcing of the Human Mind

The second channel of inheritance has a weakness: it lives in human heads, and heads are small, perishable, and unreliable. A skill is lost if the teacher dies before the student learns it. Memory fades, reasoning errs, and no single mind can hold more than a sliver of what the species knows. So civilization has gradually done for the mind what the hearth did for the body. It has moved the limitations outside.

Writing was the first great step. Information could now survive the death of the person who possessed it and travel to people who had never met him. Numerals and mathematics followed, giving humans methods of reasoning beyond the limits of unaided intuition, so that a problem too large to hold in one head could be worked out on paper. The printing press made copying cheap and spread knowledge faster than any institution could control. Mechanical calculators and ledgers took over the burden of arithmetic. Then computers expanded the scale and speed of computation far beyond what a biological brain could manage alone, and networks put much of human knowledge within reach of a search.

Look closely at that list and notice what changed. Earlier tools carried the limits of the body: warmth, strength, reach. These carry the limits of the mind: memory, calculation, retrieval. The species had begun to relocate its cognition outside the skull, one faculty at a time.

Yet every one of these tools shared a quiet feature. They stored and processed what a human gave them. The tablet did not decide what was worth recording. The calculator did not decide which problem to solve. Judgment, the choosing of what mattered and the interpreting of what it meant, stayed with the person, and the tool served it.

That was the unspoken arrangement: humans would hand away the labor of thinking, but not the thinking itself. So a question begins to form. What happens when that arrangement breaks, and intelligence itself becomes partially externalized?

Part IV: The Last Gift

Artificial intelligence is different from many of the machines that came before it. A calculator performs a calculation. A machine performs a physical action. Each does one thing, and does it only when a person decides what that thing should be. An AI system can participate in tasks that resemble parts of human cognition itself: reasoning, generating hypotheses, recognizing patterns, writing, coding, planning, and learning from enormous quantities of information.

Consider what that range implies. The same system that drafts an essay can debug a program, summarize a legal contract, suggest a molecule worth testing, or walk through a proof. Earlier tools were built for a purpose and stayed within it. This one is general in a way no previous tool was, and it was not told how to do most of these things. It acquired the capacity by absorbing patterns from the accumulated record of human thought, the same record that the second channel of inheritance had been building for thousands of years.

This is why AI is better understood as the culmination of the pattern than as a random invention. Fire externalized warmth. Writing externalized memory. Computers externalized calculation. Artificial intelligence begins to externalize the faculty that made all the earlier steps possible: the capacity to understand a problem and devise a way around it. It is the same Promethean gesture as before, with one difference. This time the gesture is aimed at the hand that has been making the gestures all along.

There is a strange self-reference in that. Every earlier externalization was a product of human intelligence. This one is human intelligence producing a version of itself. The tablet, the ledger, and the calculator were results of thinking. This is thinking, or something that does enough of what thinking does, made into a tool.

The significance of AI may therefore not lie merely in what it can do. It may lie in what happens when the defining competitive advantage of one species becomes reproducible outside that species.

That phrase deserves slowing down. A human mind cannot be copied. Each one takes decades to grow, cannot be in two places at once, tires, forgets, and takes most of what it knows with it when it dies. Intelligence has always been scarce in humans for exactly these reasons, and scarcity is part of what made it valuable. An AI system, by contrast, can in principle be copied, run in parallel, and scaled up with more hardware. If the thing that set one species apart can be duplicated at will, it stops being a trait of that species. It becomes a resource, available to anyone who can run the machine.

That brings us to the central question of this essay: what happens when the species that dominated its environment because of its intelligence creates another system that can surpass it in economically valuable forms of intelligence?

The phrasing is deliberate. The question does not ask whether machines will become conscious, or whether they will resemble us, or whether they will want anything. It asks only whether they can do, more cheaply and at greater scale, the things people have been valued for doing with their minds. That is a narrower question than science fiction usually poses, and in some ways a more unsettling one, because it requires no dramatic awakening and no hostility.

Until now, humans have extended their own hands. For the first time, they may be building something that can take up the work without them. That is the moment the story changes direction.

Part V: The Reversal

For most of human history, the causal chain ran in one direction. The environment posed a problem, humans adapted, and humans in turn changed the environment. Intelligence sat with the organism, and the world was the thing it acted upon.

Now the chain bends. Humans create AI, and AI changes the human environment.

For most of human history, intelligence was an advantage possessed by the organism itself. Humans could use it to build tools, organize societies and transform their surroundings. Artificial intelligence introduces a peculiar reversal. Humans are no longer merely using intelligence to change their environment. They are creating an external intelligence that may itself change the conditions under which humans live.

The environment is no longer purely natural, nor purely technological. It increasingly contains another form of cognition.

A hammer reshapes a world, but it does not make decisions about what to reshape. A system that can reason, plan, and act is a different kind of participant. It sits inside the environment as an agent of change rather than only as an instrument of ours.

This is where Darwin comes back into the story. His framework describes organisms shaped by environments they did not design. Humans broke that arrangement by designing parts of their own environment. So we can now ask: can the theory of natural selection still describe humans when they are capable of creating part of their own selective environment?

Part VI: When Intelligence Becomes Cheap

Suppose that artificial intelligence eventually becomes better than humans at a sufficiently broad range of economically valuable cognitive tasks. The immediate consequence would not necessarily be biological extinction. It would be something more mundane, and perhaps more consequential: economic displacement.

A human does not have to be intellectually useless to become economically unnecessary. The relevant comparison is not whether humans remain intelligent, but whether human intelligence remains scarce enough to command economic value.

Consider the domains where this could, hypothetically, play out. In software, a system that writes and debugs code at scale would change what a programmer is for. In analysis and research, a system that reads thousands of papers and proposes hypotheses would change what a research assistant is for. In design, administration, and finance, routine judgment and coordination could be performed continuously and at negligible marginal cost. In legal work, drafting and review might be done in seconds. In scientific discovery, the search through possible explanations might be partly delegated.

None of these outcomes is guaranteed, and each depends on technical progress, institutional adoption, and human choices that are far from settled. They are offered here as hypothetical domains, not predictions. What matters is the structure of the argument: if the abundance of a resource drives its price toward zero, then a species whose livelihood depended on that resource has a problem, however capable the species remains.

And so we arrive at the question: if cognitive labor becomes abundant, what happens to the economic value of human cognition?

Part VII: Not Like the Other Revolutions

The obvious reply to all of this is that we have been here before. The mechanical loom, the steam engine, the assembly line, and the computer each provoked fears of permanent mass unemployment, and each time the fear proved wrong. Displaced workers moved into new industries, and new kinds of work appeared that no one had imagined. That record is a reason for real humility, and it is the strongest argument against the thesis of this essay.

But the record carries a hidden condition. Every earlier revolution replaced something specific, and what it replaced was mostly muscle. The steam engine replaced strength. The assembly line replaced skilled hands. Even the early computer replaced clerical arithmetic. In every case there was somewhere for displaced people to go, and the place they went was the mind. The farmhand became the factory worker, the factory worker became the office worker, and the office worker became the analyst. Cognition was the escape hatch through which each wave of displaced labor climbed.

Artificial intelligence is aimed at the escape hatch itself.

The difference shows up in at least four ways. The first is breadth. Earlier machines were narrow, each taking over a particular task or sector, which left the rest of the economy to absorb the people who were let go. General-purpose cognition applies everywhere at once, so there may be no neighboring industry to retreat to. The second is complementarity. Past technologies mostly raised the value of human thinking, creating demand for engineers, managers, and designers to build and run the machines. A system that can do the engineering, management, and design substitutes for the thing the earlier machines depended on.

The third is the ladder. Earlier transitions still left humans with the new, harder, higher-skilled jobs the technology created. If a system can also perform the new tasks, then the process that historically generated fresh work may stall at the point where it needs a human to invent or perform it. The fourth is speed. A weaver in 1820 had a working lifetime to adjust, and his children had a

generation to retrain. Software can be copied and deployed globally at almost no cost, with no factories to build and no railways to lay.

The history of the horse is a sobering comparison. For thousands of years, horses were essential to transport, farming, and war, and their numbers grew with the economy. Then engines took over their work. Within a few decades, the horse population in the United States fell from a peak of roughly twenty million to just a few million. The horses were not unintelligent or lazy. They simply stopped being the cheapest way to do what needed doing. The analogy is imperfect in a crucial way: horses had no vote, no voice, and no institutions of their own, while humans have all three, and Part XIII returns to why that matters. But it shows what can happen when a technology replaces not a task, but the main reason a species was needed.

This does not prove that the old pattern will fail. It suggests that its past success was never a law of nature. It depended on humans keeping a cognitive edge, and that edge is exactly what is now in question.

Part VIII: From Economic Selection to Biological Selection

It would be too simple to say that humans lose their jobs and then humans die. That is not how either economies or evolution work, and the essay is only worth writing if it respects the gap between them.

Economic systems do not directly determine evolution, but they influence the conditions under which humans live. Access to food, shelter, healthcare, education, social status and the ability to raise children is mediated, to a large degree, by economic and social institutions. If technological change radically alters the distribution of economic power, it may also alter patterns of survival and reproduction.

Natural selection would only follow if those altered conditions produced persistent differences in reproductive success associated with heritable traits. But the possibility is enough to raise a deeper question: could an economic transformation produced by artificial intelligence eventually become an evolutionary pressure?

The caveat here is essential. Economic displacement is not automatically Darwinian selection. A person can lose income without losing the ability to have healthy children, and even where reproduction rates differ between groups, selection requires that the difference track heritable traits rather than circumstances, culture, or chance. Most of the inequalities humans have lived with throughout history have not, in fact, reshaped the species.

With that said, a hypothesis remains: economic extinction could become a precursor to biological decline. It is not inevitable. It is a possible pathway, and a pathway is something worth examining precisely because it is not yet a destination.

Part IX: The Problem of Timescale

There is another problem hidden inside the argument. Biological evolution is slow. Technological change can be extraordinarily fast. A population may require many generations for natural selection to substantially alter the frequency of heritable traits, while a technological system can transform an industry within a few years.

The species may therefore encounter an unusual evolutionary situation: its environment may be changing faster than biological evolution can respond.

The mismatch is stark when put in numbers of generations. A human generation lasts roughly two or three decades. Meaningful shifts in the frequency of a trait rather occur over the course of many generations, which means decades to centuries. A software system, by contrast, can be redesigned and redeployed in months. The selective environment, if AI is part of it, could change faster than human genetic evolution could respond.

This cuts in two directions. On one hand, it suggests that any pressure created by AI would be hard for natural selection to answer, since there would simply not be time for favorable variations to spread. On the other, it suggests that natural selection may be the wrong lens for the problem. If the environment shifts faster than genes can track it, then what actually happens will be decided by other mechanisms long before biology has a say.

So we can ask: what happens when natural selection is too slow to solve the problem?

The answer leads naturally to the next section.

Part X: Humans Have Another Way to Adapt

It would be a mistake to turn this into a straight-line story of decline, because humans have something most species lack, or have only in rudimentary form: cultural and technological adaptation.

Humans do not rely exclusively on biological evolution. They have another mechanism of adaptation: culture. A species incapable of growing thicker fur can invent clothing within a generation. A species incapable of flying can build an aircraft within centuries. Humans repeatedly solve biological problems technologically rather than genetically.

The same may happen with intelligence. If the pressure comes from machines that think faster, the response need not be a human who thinks faster. It could be a human who is better equipped.

Several possibilities are already visible in outline. AI augmentation would put capable assistants in the hands of ordinary people, raising what an individual can accomplish. Human-machine interfaces might narrow the gap between thought and tool. Genetic modification could, in principle, shift the biological baseline itself, though it raises profound ethical and practical questions. AI-assisted education could help people learn faster and more deeply than before. Cognitive prostheses, in the broad sense of tools that extend memory, attention, and reasoning, could do for the mind what eyeglasses did for the eye.

The key idea is that humans may not need to become biologically smarter than AI if they become better at working with AI.

That possibility creates a competing future, and it deserves to be held up against the first.

Part XI: The Accelerant

There is a complication. So far the argument has treated the pace of change as fast but fixed. There are reasons to suspect that the pace is itself increasing, and two feedback loops are worth separating.

The first loop: faster intelligence, faster decline

Every outsourced faculty is one that the person no longer exercises. This worry is old. In Plato's *Phaedrus*, Socrates fears that writing will weaken memory by letting people rely on marks instead of recollection. Some studies suggest that heavy reliance on navigation apps weakens spatial memory, and few people today can do long division with the fluency their grandparents had.

What is new is the breadth of what is being handed over. Earlier tools took over narrow tasks such as remembering, counting, or looking things up. AI can take over drafting, analysis, planning, and problem-solving, which are the very activities through which people build expertise in the first place. If the entry-level tasks that once trained novices are automated, the ladder that produced skilled people may lose its lower rungs. The result is a double erosion: human cognition loses economic value because machines do the work cheaply, and loses some of its depth because people practice it less.

The loop then reinforces itself. The more capable the system, the more sensible it is to delegate to it. The more people delegate, the less able they are to check the system's work, and the more they depend on it. The more they depend on it, the less reason there is to practice. A faster, more capable intelligence does not merely outcompete people at a given moment. It may speed up the weakening of the capacities that would let people compete, or even supervise, later on.

This is a hypothesis, not a certainty. Chess engines surpassed every human player, yet human players did not stop improving. Many trained with the engines and became stronger than any generation before them. Decline is only one possible response to a powerful tool, and it depends heavily on whether people use the tool to learn or to avoid learning.

The second loop: models improving models

The second loop concerns who does the work of making intelligence better. Humans have so far been the ones improving AI, but AI systems increasingly assist with that work too: writing code, running experiments, and helping design the next generation of systems. The idea of recursive self-improvement is that once a system is good enough at AI research, each generation helps build a more capable successor, and capability compounds.

Whether this produces runaway gains or runs into diminishing returns is genuinely contested. Progress still depends on hardware, energy, data, and experiments that take real time to run, and any of these could act as a brake. But the possibility changes the shape of the argument, because human intelligence has no equivalent loop. The biological hardware of the human brain is essentially fixed. Culture accumulates knowledge, but each generation still starts with the same neurons.

Put the two loops together and the gap widens from both sides. Machine capability may compound while unaided human capability stays flat or erodes. In Part IX the problem was that biology runs on a slow clock while technology runs on a faster one. Here, the faster clock itself may be speeding up.

That puts pressure on the very mechanism the previous section relied upon. Cultural adaptation is far faster than genetic adaptation, but it still takes time: schools must be redesigned, institutions must learn, laws must be written, and people must retrain. If the environment changes faster than those processes can respond, even the fast human way of adapting could be too slow. So the question becomes sharper: what happens when even the quick mechanism of adaptation cannot keep up?

Part XII: The Evolutionary Fork

We can now sketch two broad possibilities without pretending that either is certain.

Path A: Symbiosis

In the first path, humans integrate AI into civilization rather than being displaced by it. The individual human remains biologically limited, but operates as part of a much larger cognitive system, in the way a single neuron is unremarkable while a brain is not. Education, work, medicine, and governance are rebuilt around collaboration between people and machines, and the benefits of that collaboration are widely shared.

Perhaps the successor to individual human intelligence is not artificial intelligence alone, but a hybrid intelligence in which biological and artificial cognition become inseparable.

Path B: Redundancy

In the second path, humans fail to adapt economically and institutionally. The pace of change outruns the ability of schools, labor markets, and governments to respond. AI performs more and more of the work needed to maintain civilization, and human participation becomes progressively less necessary to keep the machinery running.

The species that once reshaped its environment may discover that it has become one of the least necessary components of the environment it created.

These are not predictions. They are two ends of a spectrum of trajectories, offered so that the argument can be tested against them. The real future would almost certainly mix elements of both, and which elements dominate would depend far more on human decisions than on any inevitability in the technology.

Part XIII: The Extinction Question

Now we can confront the question this essay has been circling.

Extinction would not require artificial intelligence to hate humans. It would not even require AI to deliberately eliminate the species. Evolution has never required hatred. A species can disappear simply because the conditions that sustained it disappear.

If human beings became economically unnecessary, technologically dependent and reproductively disadvantaged for long enough, biological decline could theoretically follow. The danger would not be a machine deciding that humans should die. It could be something colder: a world in which humans gradually cease to be necessary.

That line of reasoning is much more Darwinian than the familiar robot-apocalypse story. There is no villain in it, no moment of rebellion, no war. There is only a changing environment and a population that no longer fits it.

But is economic irrelevance actually enough to cause extinction? There are good reasons to think it is not.

Humans could retain political control. Economic usefulness and political power are different things, and societies routinely protect people who produce little. Societies could distribute AI-generated abundance, so that the end of scarce cognitive labor means cheaper goods and more leisure rather than destitution. Humans could deliberately protect reproduction and welfare, through policy, culture, and the simple fact that people care about one another and their children. Augmentation could preserve competitiveness, as the previous sections suggested. And technological dependence does not equal biological extinction: humans have depended on fire and agriculture for millennia, and the dependence did not doom them.

Taken together, these points are a serious check on the argument. They do not show that the dangerous path is impossible. They show that it is one path among several, and that the outcome depends on choices rather than on fate. That is the difference between a warning and a prophecy, and this essay aims to be the former.

Part XIV: The Prometheus Return

This essay began with Prometheus, and it is time to bring him back.

Prometheus gave the species fire and thereby altered its relationship with nature. Fire allowed humans to overcome constraints that had once belonged to the body. For thousands of years, humans repeated the same gesture, creating tools that allowed them to escape one limitation after another.

Then it created artificial intelligence.

The first fire allowed humans to change the environment.

The second fire may allow humans to create an intelligence capable of changing the environment back.

It is a strange symmetry. The first fire made the world more hospitable to a fragile animal. The second might make the world more hospitable to something else, and the animal's place in it would then be an open question. What fire could not do, and what no earlier tool could do, is act on its own account within the world it was built to serve.

Ending

Darwin gave us a humbling picture of life: organisms shaped, slowly and without mercy, by environments they never chose. For most of history we lived inside that picture, made by the cold, the hunger, and the dark. Then something extraordinary happened. A fragile animal with no fur, no claws, and no great speed looked at the world that was shaping it and began, stubbornly, to shape it back.

Fire, language, agriculture, machines, computers. Each was a refusal to let the body have the last word. Each carried a limit out of the flesh and into the world, and each time the species grew larger than its biology. We outran the cold. We outran hunger. We outran, for a time, even our own forgetting. It may be the most remarkable thing a living creature has ever done: to turn its own weakness into a lever.

But every earlier gift shared one quiet feature: it served a mind that stayed in human hands. The fire did not decide what to cook. The tablet did not decide what to remember. Intelligence remained ours, the one thing we kept for ourselves while we gave everything else away.

Now we are building something that reaches for that last possession. Not merely a tool that obeys, but an intelligence that can enter the very environment that intelligence once let us master, and that may one day shape it as well as we can, or better. We are the first species to build a mind that is not its own and set it loose in the world that shapes us all.

There is something both magnificent and unsettling in that. Magnificent, because it is the same impulse that raised the first hearth: the refusal to accept a limit. Unsettling, because we do not yet know what it means to share a world with a mind we cannot outthink, and because nature has never been sentimental about those who are no longer needed.

Perhaps this will become another tool, another adaptation, another fire: one more extension of the hand that made it, carrying us further than we have ever been. History gives us reasons for hope as well as dread.

Or perhaps the greatest evolutionary advantage our species ever possessed, the one thing that lifted us out of the dark, will turn out to be the very thing that creates its successor.

Prometheus gave us fire and was punished for it. We built the second fire ourselves, with no god to steal from and no one to blame. It may prove to be his last gift to us, and our last gift to ourselves. The question is whether it will light the way forward, or show us, too late and by its own light, that we have finally made something we cannot evolve past.